

CUSTOMER SERVICE ESSENTIALS: LEVEL 1

Customer Service Essentials: Level 1 — Day 2: First Contact and Finding the Real Problem

Study guide · Self-study

Day 2: First Contact and Finding the Real Problem

How to Use This Guide

This is Day 2 of Customer Service Essentials: Level 1. On Day 1 you learned what the job looks like: the channels, what a ticket is, and what a customer has already lost by the time they reach you. Today you learn the skill behind almost everything else in this course: how to open a contact well, and how to find the real problem behind the first complaint.

Work through the sections in order. Do the "What Would You Say?" exercises before you look at the model answers at the end. That order matters. Writing your own answer first shows you what you already know, and it makes the model answers useful instead of something to copy.

You need no job to use this guide. Every exercise works as a role-play with a friend, a recording of yourself, or a mock call you set up alone. Read one section, then practice it out loud. A structure you have only read is not yet a structure you can use.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know the four steps of the First-Contact Standard (Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity) and the four rungs of the Question Ladder (Situation, Problem, Impact, Need).

Attitude: You will treat the first contact as something you design, not something that happens to you, and you will accept that the customer's first sentence is rarely the whole problem.

Skill: You will be able to open a contact the customer chooses to continue, repeat their reason back in their own words, split the event from the impact, and ask how and what questions instead of why.

Upskill: You will run one full practice contact using all four steps and all four rungs, in order, and write one follow-up that uses a how or what question.

The First-Contact Standard: An Opening the Customer Chooses to Continue

First-Contact Standard (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Kahneman, Brehm and Guyer et al.) is a four-behavior structure for every first contact, used in this order: Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity. It is a structure, not a script. Its goal is an opening the other person chooses to continue: one that earns attention instead of demanding it.

The order follows the customer's silent questions in the first seconds: Is this safe? Is this relevant? Do I want to continue? Understand why those questions come in that order. In Day 1 you learned about two speeds of thinking. First contact lands on the fast one. The customer is not judging the solution yet; they are deciding whether this conversation is a problem or not. A calm, unhurried opening answers "safe" before they have to ask. Pressure at the start triggers reactance: the urge to push back against anything that feels forced. That is why the Standard begins with Low Threat and not with questions about the problem.

Step 1, Low Threat: open calmly and unhurried, and say who you are and who you represent at a natural pace. Step 2, Autonomy: give the customer control over how the contact runs, such as where it continues (chat or callback) or what to look at first. In a contact the customer started, never offer a way to end it. Step 3, Relevance: give one true, credible reason this contact is about them, not you.

Step 4, Curiosity: ask one easy, open question that invites them to talk. It has exactly 4 steps, and you use them in this order every time.

Here is the point people most often miss about Autonomy. In this course the customer usually starts the contact. Your job is not to offer them a way out the door. Autonomy means giving the customer control over how the contact runs. Not "would you like to call back another time?", which ends the contact. Instead: "Would you rather I sort this here in chat, or have me call you back within the hour?" That is a real choice about the shape of the contact, and both options keep the problem moving. The customer feels in charge, so the resistance that comes from feeling trapped never builds. This is why giving people control makes them more willing to stay engaged, not less.

Practice example: The customer opens the chat: "My parcel was meant to arrive two days ago and the tracking hasn't moved." Sam replies: "Hi, this is Sam from Northline Home Support. I can see the tracking has stopped moving, and I can help with that. Would you rather I check the courier here in chat, or have me call you back within the hour with an update? And so I get this right: what has the delay affected for you so far?"

Notice what that reply does. It is calm. It says plainly who Sam is. It gives a real choice about how the contact runs. It gives one true reason the contact is about the customer. It ends with an easy, open question. Nothing in it pressures anyone.

> **NOTES**
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> A common first mistake is skipping the name and the reason to rush to the question. Slow down on the first two lines.

Relevance: Repeat Their Reason Back in Their Own Words

Relevance is the third step of the First-Contact Standard, and it has a specific behavior attached to it: repeat the customer's reason back in their own words. Not your summary of it, and not your category for it. Their words.

Why does this matter so much? Because the customer has already had a hard day by the time they reach you. Day 1 called sharp words safety signals. A customer who opens with "this is the second time I've been sent the wrong part" is not attacking you; they are telling you what they have lost. When you say back, "So this is the second time you've been sent the wrong part", two things happen. First, they know they have been heard, which lowers the emotional temperature. Second, they check your version and correct it if it is wrong. Both outcomes help you.

Watch what happens if you skip the repeat-back. The customer says their first sentence, and you say, "No problem, I can look into that." It sounds helpful. But they did not need a lookup; they needed confirmation that you understood. So they repeat themselves, louder, and the contact gets harder. The repeat-back is not politeness. It is the cheapest way to stop a customer having to say the same thing twice.

Practice example: Customer: "I ordered a replacement filter and got the wrong size, and now my machine is sitting idle." You: "The filter came in the wrong size, and your machine is idle because of

it." One sentence, their words, no "but" after it. Then wait. Most customers will add the detail that really matters.

Splitting the Event from the Impact

Customers describe the event. They react to the impact. Learn that split and you will understand why so many contacts go wrong.

The event is what happened: "the wrong size filter was delivered." The impact is what it cost them: "my machine is idle, and every hour it sits costs me." Customers open with the event because it is visible and easy to state. The impact often stays unsaid, because it is bigger, more personal and less comfortable to admit.

If you fix the event and never learn the impact, you have solved half the problem and you don't know it. Worse, you may choose a fix that is fine by the event and useless by the impact. Suppose a customer says their delivery is late. You can re-send it on the standard schedule, which fixes the event. But if the impact is an appointment tomorrow morning, the re-send fails. The customer says you were no help, and you genuinely don't understand why.

This is why the Question Ladder below matters so much, and why the Impact rung is the one most learners skip.

> **NOTES**
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> Listen for words like "now", "again" and "every day". They usually sit right before the impact.

The Question Ladder: From First Complaint to Real Problem

The Question Ladder (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Rackham) is a four-rung question structure, climbed in order: Situation, Problem, Impact, Need. Impact is the rung most people skip. It has exactly 4 steps.

Rung 1, Situation: "What's happening on your side right now?" You establish facts: what the order was, what arrived, which channel the customer used. Rung 2, Problem: "What's been hardest about this so far?" You let the customer name the difficulty in their words. Rung 3, Impact: "What does this mean for you if it isn't sorted today?" This is the rung most people skip; resist that. Rung 4, Need: "What would help most right now?" You hand the customer the choice of resolution.

Why climb in order? Because each rung earns the right to the next. Asking about impact before the customer has described the problem feels intrusive, and it shows. And why is Impact so powerful? Asking about consequences makes a customer explain, in their own words, why the problem matters. That is not just done so you can hear it; the customer hears it too. They move from telling you what happened to telling you what it costs, and that is the moment they start working with you rather than at you.

The psychology here has a name. Asking about consequences was central to Neil Rackham's research on sales questioning (SPIN questioning: Situation, Problem, Implication, Need-payoff). The Ladder is

MEDJAY's own adaptation of it, with the rungs renamed for service contacts. You can name this idea to yourself as SPIN questioning from Rackham's work. You don't need to name it to the customer; you need to practice it.

Practice example: "What happened when the delivery arrived?" then "What's been hardest since then?" then "What does the idle machine mean for you this week?" then "What would help most right now?" Four questions, in order, then a pause after each.

Why "Why" Puts People on the Defensive

"Why" is an open word, so many people assume it is safe. It isn't. In a service contact, "why" asks for a reason, and reasons sound like blame. "Why did you use the wrong address?" and "Why didn't you check the box?" both ask the customer to justify themselves. And defensiveness is expensive: a customer who feels accused defends instead of explains, and the real problem disappears behind the defense.

Chris Voss's work on negotiation makes the same point: why tends to sound like an accusation, while calibrated how and what questions invite the other person to think and explain. Calibrated questions: "how" and "what" invite people to think and explain rather than say yes or no. So the customer's answer helps you both. Compare: "Why was the machine running with the wrong filter?" with "What happened at the moment the machine went idle?" Same information. The second one is easier to answer honestly.

Rewrite every "why" before it leaves your mouth. "Why did you choose a different option?" becomes "What made that option fit better?" "Why didn't you tell us sooner?" becomes "What was happening on your side that week?" You will feel the difference the first time you hear a customer answer without defending.

> **NOTES**
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> If you catch yourself starting a sentence with "why", stop, and ask again starting with "what".

Worked Example

Practice example: A customer opens in chat: "Your courier delivered the wrong part, and your replacement is late. Again."

Weak version: "Sorry about that. Can I have your order number? I'll re-send it." This is a yes/no door and a standard fix. The customer gives the number, gets a re-send, and leaves quietly. Nobody learns the part was needed for a repair scheduled the next morning. The contact counts as resolved. The customer does not return.

Strong version, using the Standard and the Ladder:

"Hello, this is Priya from Northline Home Support. I'm sorry this has been a mess, and I can help. Would you rather I sort the re-send here in chat, or have me call you back within the hour about it? And so I get this right: what was the part for?

(Situation, with repeat-back) So the wrong part arrived and the replacement is late, and this is the second time.

(Problem) What has been hardest about this?

(Impact) And what does that mean for the repair you have planned?

(Need) What would help most right now, knowing what you've told me?"

Suppose the customer answers that the repair is booked for 8am tomorrow. Now you have the real problem: not "wrong part", but "repair tomorrow morning". You can suggest options honestly. Suppose the customer says, "I need the part before 8." You reply: "Would you rather I check whether a pick-up is possible this afternoon and call you back within the hour, or pause the re-send and confirm the time first?" That is a real choice with a date, not a "shall I look into it?" The customer still decides, and they can still say no. You end the contact knowing what actually mattered, and the customer remembers that someone asked.

> **NOTES**
>
> The opening already asks what the part was for. When you climb the ladder, don't ask it again; move on to Problem.

Apply It in Your Role

Phone: open with all four steps of the First-Contact Standard before you touch a screen. Then climb all four rungs of the Question Ladder. Your goal is not the fastest possible resolution; it is a resolved problem and a customer who trusts you.

Chat: keep the same four steps, but shorter. "Hi, I'm Priya at Northline. I can help with this. Would you rather I keep going here in chat, or call you back in ten minutes? So I get it right: what has the late delivery affected?" Then climb.

Service counter: smile, say your name, and give the customer the first move: "What brings you in today?" Then ask the Problem and Impact questions while you look at the item. The customer is standing in front of you; use the time.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer before reading the model answers at the end.

1. A customer opens a chat with: "Third time I've contacted you about this refund." Write your opening, using all four steps of the First-Contact Standard.

2. A customer says: "My order arrived with the wrong item." Write the sentence where you repeat their reason back, plus one Problem question and one Impact question.

3. Convert these three "why" questions into how or what questions: "Why didn't you check the box?" "Why did you order that size?" "Why are you calling now?"

4. A customer says: "I'm returning this, it's broken." Show how you would climb all four rungs of the Question Ladder, then write a closing question that uses a real choice with a date.

5. Write one follow-up message to a customer you helped today in a practice scenario, using a how or what question, and confirming what happens next.

Key Takeaways

- The customer usually starts the contact. Your goal is a resolved problem and a customer who trusts you. The first contact is a structure you design, not a conversation you wait for.
- The First-Contact Standard has four steps, used in order: Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity. It gives the customer something they choose to continue with.
- Autonomy means the customer chooses how the contact runs, not whether it continues.
- Relevance means repeating their reason back in their own words, and then splitting the event from the impact.
- The Question Ladder has four rungs: Situation, Problem, Impact, Need. Impact is the one people skip, and the one that changes the resolution.
- Never ask "why" in a service contact. Ask "what" and "how" instead.
- Write down what you learned and use it next time. A question that changes nothing is just conversation.

Quiz

Answer all five questions. Choose one option per question.

1. What are the four steps of the First-Contact Standard, in order?

A. Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity

B. Situation, Problem, Impact, Need

C. Greeting, Question, Answer, Close

D. Relevance, Low Threat, Curiosity, Autonomy

2. A customer has already started the contact about a late refund. Which sentence shows Autonomy as this course teaches it?

A. "Would you like to call back another time?"

B. "Shall I go ahead and process this?"

C. "Would you rather I resolve this here in chat, or have me call you back within the hour?"

D. "Why didn't you tell us sooner?"

3. Why do we repeat the customer's reason back in their own words as part of Relevance?

A. To show we can use the customer's wording.

B. To confirm we heard them correctly and to stop them repeating themselves.

C. To move faster toward a resolution.

D. To close the ticket.

4. Which rung of the Question Ladder is the one most people skip?

   A. Situation

   B. Problem

   C. Impact

   D. Need

5. A customer says: "I'm returning this, it's broken." Which question should you avoid in a service contact?

   A. "What happened when you opened it?"

   B. "And what has this meant for your schedule?"

   C. "What would help most right now?"

   D. "Why didn't you tell us sooner?"

Upskill Challenge

Do this before Day 3, and use only role-play, a recording of yourself, or a mock call. You need no job to complete it.

- ☐ Write three "what" or "how" questions you will use in your practice contact, and say each one out loud until it sounds like your own words.
- ☐ Run one role-play contact with a friend as the customer, or record a mock call with yourself taking both sides.
- ☐ Use all four steps of the First-Contact Standard, in order, and all four rungs of the Question Ladder, in order, in that same contact.
- ☐ Say the customer's reason back in their own words at least once, and split the event from the impact in your follow-up.
- ☐ Write down each question you asked, what it revealed and what you did with the answer.
- ☐ Write one follow-up message to the customer that ends with a how or what question and states exactly what happens next.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you. What matters is the principle behind each answer.

Model answer for 1 (opening a third-contact refund chat):

"Hi, this is (your name) from (your company). I can see this is the third time you've contacted us about the refund, and I'm sorry that's happened. I can help get this sorted. Would you rather I keep going here in chat, or have me call you back within thirty minutes? And so I focus on the right thing: what did you originally buy, and what has the wait meant for you?"

Why it works: it opens calmly, is clear about who you are, gives control over how the contact runs without ending it, and asks one easy, open question.

Model answer for 2 (wrong item):

"That's frustrating. Just so I have this straight: the wrong item arrived. What have you had to do differently today because of it? And what would it mean for you if this isn't sorted before the weekend?"

Why it works: it labels the feeling lightly, repeats the reason back in the customer's own words, then asks a Problem question before an Impact question.

Model answer for 3 (why into what or how):

"Why didn't you check the box?" → "What did you see on the label when it arrived?"

"Why did you order that size?" → "What made that size the right fit for you at the time?"

"Why are you calling now?" → "What has changed since the last time you got in touch?"

Why it works: each question asks for the same information and makes it easier to answer honestly.

Model answer for 4 (four rungs, then a real choice with a date):

"I can help with a return. (Situation) What did you order, and when did it arrive? (Problem) What happened when you opened it? (Impact) What does this mean for the job you were going to use it for? (Need) What would help most right now? And with what you've told me: would you rather I arrange a replacement that arrives by Thursday, or process the return today and call you with a date this afternoon?"

Why it works: it climbs in order, then offers a genuine choice with dates, not a yes/no question. The customer can still say no.

Model answer for 5 (follow-up message):

"Hi (name), I've logged your return and confirmed the pick-up for Thursday. To make sure this doesn't happen again: what would make the packaging clearer for the next order?"

Why it works: it states exactly what has been done and confirmed, then ends with a how or what question that invites useful information.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. A. The four steps are Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity, and they are always used in this order.
- 2. C. Autonomy in a customer-started contact means the customer chooses how the contact runs.
- 3. B. When you say their reason back in their own words, they know they were heard, and they check your version.
- 4. C. Impact is the rung most people skip, and it is the one that surfaces the real problem.
- 5. D. "Why" sounds like blame and puts the customer on the defensive, so ask what or how instead.

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